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Addressing global inequities in agriculture

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E-CHAPTER FROM THIS BOOK



Socio-cultural factors and women smallholder farmers' empowerment in Uganda

Brenda Boonabaana, The University of Texas at Austin, USA; Florence Kyoheirwe Muhanguzi, Losira Nasirumbi Sanya, Susan Namirembe Kavuma, Grace Kyomuhendo Bantebya and Pius Okello, Makerere University, Uganda; Laura Meinzen-Dick, Villanova University, USA; and Nargiza Ludgate, University of Florida, USA

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1 Introduction

Agriculture remains an important sector for most African economies, accounting for 14% of total GDP in sub-Saharan Africa (SSA). It is the primary source of food for human beings and fodder for animals, as well as a source of raw materials for agro-based industries (Food and Agricultural Organization [FAO] et al., 2020). The agricultural sector employs a sizable proportion of the rural population, the majority of whom are women, ranging from 19.9% in Botswana, 76.4% in Malawi (World Bank, 2023) and 81.2% in Uganda (FAO, 2023). In low-income landlocked countries such as Chad, farming makes up over 50% of GDP with over 75% of the population in subsistence farming. Crop production accounts for more than 75% of the total agricultural production on the African continent, with the main crops grown being wheat (mainly in North Africa), tubers and plantains (Central and West Africa), and maize (mainly in Southern

Africa). In 2021/2022, agriculture accounted for about 24.1% of GDP and 33% of export earnings (International Trade Administration [ITA], 2022). Around 80% of agricultural households engage in crop and livestock production both for their own consumption and income generation. The major food crops grown in Uganda are maize (55%), beans (54%), bananas (47%), cassava (29%), cereals (sesame, soybean, sunflower, millet and sorghum), sweet potatoes, vegetables, groundnuts, plantains and Irish potatoes (Uganda Investment Authority [UIA], 2023). The main cash crops grown in Uganda include coffee, tea, sugar, cotton and tobacco (Uganda Bureau of Statistics [UBOS], 2018; UIA, 2023).

As farming continues to loom large in the development possibilities of Africa, women constitute one vital human resource for the African agricultural sector (Amenyah and Puplampu, 2013). As primary drivers of African economies and local communities, women constitute more than 40% of the global agricultural labour force (Matthew et al., 2022; JICA, 2023). In Sub-Saharan Africa, 66% of women's employment is in agri-food systems compared to 60% of men (FAO, 2023). In countries such as Ethiopia, Malawi, Niger, Nigeria, Tanzania, Zambia and Uganda, women's share of labour in crop production ranges between 40% and 78% (World Bank, 2023). In Uganda, over 80% of the women derive their livelihoods from agriculture (Civil Society Budget Advocacy Group [CSBAG], 2022; UBOS, 2018; UN Women, 2018), depicting the critical role of agriculture to African women's wellbeing.

However, women in agriculture experience a myriad of challenges that constrain their contributions and benefits. These include their limited participation in decision-making over crops grown, activities to be undertaken and control of income from high-value cash and food crops (Carter et al., 2017; Peralta, 2021). Cash crops such as cotton, cocoa, coffee and cereals including maize, barley and wheat are often controlled by men, while food crops which are largely for household consumption such as plantains (bananas), sweet potatoes, sorghum, millet and vegetables, remain typically 'women's crops' (Alinyo and Leahy, 2012; Ali et al., 2015). Fruit tree species with a high market potential are also controlled by men, while women mainly control fruit tree species with a lesser market potential but offer products for domestic use like firewood and medicine (Twinorugyendo, 2019). Further, men are much more likely to engage in market-oriented work (agribusiness) and to obtain off-farm employment, while women face significant constraints to these opportunities, including being unpaid or less-paid workers (UBOS, 2014). As consumers, women are more likely to be food insecure than men in every region of the world; and as producers, rural women particularly face much greater constraints than their men in accessing essential productive resources and services, technology, market information and financial assets (FAO, 2018).

To date, an understanding of women's role in livestock production in developing countries has been limited to cultural biases that underestimate

women's contribution with a tendency to view livestock as male enterprise. Yet evidence shows that women have more contact with animals and play a key role in livestock production particularly in the aspects of milk and meat production, hide processing, caring, feeding, birthing, processing of products, cleaning udders, milking, preparing milk for sale, selling milk products, cleaning cattle sheds, watering cattle, harvesting fodder and other daily dairy-related activities (Barnes, Mumma and Cumming, 2018; Tangka, Jabbar and Shapiro, 2020; Bonis-Profumo et al., 2022; Galiè et al., 2022, 2023). Despite, the key roles women play, they occupy the less lucrative nodes of the livestock value chain (Allan et al., 2023) and often have limited control over the process of decision-making, particularly over the disposal of animals and animal products for income (IFAD, 2013; Bonis-Profumo et al., 2022). The limited technical skills in animal care, technology, markets and marketing skills, and financial services limit women's opportunities to access, control and expand their small ruminant stock and production (Bikaako et al., 2022). In many African societies, large animals such as cattle are owned by men while smaller stock/animals such as goats, sheep, pigs and backyard poultry kept in the homestead are more a woman's domain (Allan et al., 2023; Zole, 2011). However, when small animals become an important source of family income, ownership, management and control are often turned over to the man (IFAD, 2013).

Apart from women-led value chains, participation of women in upper levels of the value chains, such as lead farmers and aggregators is restricted, with men dominating the high-value positions in processing, marketing and trading activities (Rubin, Boonabaana and Manfre, 2019; Rubin and Manfre, 2014). This is due to gender constraints around financial access, mobility, decision making and input (Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa [AGRA], 2018). For instance, African women perform most of their agricultural work using rudimentary practices and technologies (Leon-Himmelstine et al., 2021) while men make use of labour-saving technologies (machinery) (FAO, 2018; Rubin, Boonabaana and Manfre, 2019). In Uganda, women are unable to scale up to the level required for high-value crops due to constraints associated with small plot sizes, plot quality and/or ownership (Mukasa and Salami, 2015). In addition, men have more access to and use of improved seeds than women (UBOS, 2012). Women perform most of the post-harvest activities while men dominate the decision-making roles of the activities (Mwinuka and Hyera 2022). Access to resources is often determined by social rules, norms and institutions that govern the distribution and exchange of these resources (Golla et al. 2011).

Further, women's heavy workload at the household level constrains their engagement in multiple agricultural enterprises associated with crop and livestock production (AGRA, 2018; Bikaako et al., 2022). In most African societies, women are discouraged from taking on traditional roles, especially if they threaten male power and superiority (Guloba et al., 2018). Identifying

and supporting women's roles as livestock owners, processors and users of livestock products while strengthening their decision-making power and capabilities, would be critical for women's economic and social empowerment. Such discriminatory gender positioning and norms are rooted in religious and patriarchal kinship systems (Yisehak, 2008; Zole, 2011; IFAD, 2013) that define most African societies, including Uganda.

Sexsmith et al. (2017) note that gender discrimination in credit markets makes it more difficult for women farmers to acquire labour-saving and innovative production inputs. Evidence in Africa shows a substantial gender gap in mean yield of around 20–30% in favour of male farmers (Ali et al., 2015). A report by FAO (2011) demonstrates that if African smallholder women farmers had equal access to land, labour, information, technology, fertilizer, water and equal opportunity to use these resources effectively, agricultural productivity would increase by 20% in the continent. Similarly, UN Women, UNDP and World Bank (2015, p. 5) have noted that 'closing the gender gap in agricultural productivity could potentially lift as many as 238,000 people out of poverty in Malawi, 80,000 people in Tanzania, and 119,000 people in Uganda.'

This chapter draws on Kabeer's (1999, 2001) conceptualization of empowerment, defined as the ability to make strategic life choices, and to put those choices into desired actions and outcomes (Kabeer 1999). It enables women to participate on equal terms with men in society, especially, equal access to resources and decision-making power. As a multidimensional process, empowerment describes the different facets of agency as intrinsic (*power within*), instrumental (*power to*) and collective agency (*power with*) (Malapit et al., 2019; Kabeer 1999; Mulema, et al., 2021). Drawing on a mixed methods approach and document review, focused on Uganda, this chapter interrogates social-cultural influences of women smallholder farmers' empowerment and agricultural opportunities. In the first part, we present the methodology, followed by findings on the status of rural women's empowerment, local understanding and perceptions about women's empowerment and the social-cultural dynamics, and implications for women's agricultural opportunities. It ends with conclusions and recommendations.

2 Methodology

This chapter utilized literature from studies conducted on the African continent and primary data from a mixed methods baseline survey undertaken in two regions of Uganda. This is part of an ongoing research titled 'strengthening women smallholders' resilience to agricultural shocks for enhanced income diversification and empowerment in Uganda.' Data were collected from a sample of 1280 women smallholder farmers and their main decision makers in their household. For quantitative participants, we used systematic random

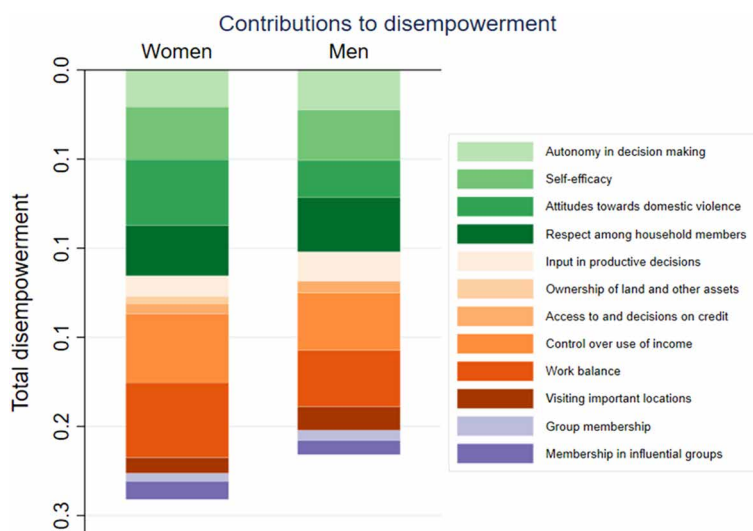


Figure 1 Indicator contributions to men and women's disempowerment.

sampling to select married women smallholder farmers that belonged to selected savings groups, aged between 18 and 64 years. For qualitative data, a total of 32 individual interviews (Life Histories), 19 Key Informant Interviews (KIs), 32 male and female focus group discussions (FGDs), 8 mixed-sex community profiles and 8 seasonality pattern group discussions, in the two study districts – Isingiro in South Western Uganda and Alebtong in Northern Uganda. The participants were selected using snowball and purposive sampling procedures.

Quantitative data analysis utilized STATA software to compute the Project Level Women Empowerment in Agriculture Index (pro-WEAI) based on three domains of empowerment (3DE) colour-coded in *Fig. 1*: intrinsic agency (green), instrumental agency (orange) and collective agency (purple). The 3DE considers 12 indicators whereby, for each indicator, an individual who is considered adequate (empowered) receives a score of 1 while one considered inadequate (disempowered) receives a score of 0. The 12 scores are then equally weighted for an average 3DE score and a Gender Parity Index (GPI)¹ with a weight of 10%, to give a composite empowerment score that ranges between 0 and 1. Individuals with a score above 75% (adequate in 9/12 indicators) are considered to be empowered while those with a score below 75% (inadequate in 4 or more indicators) are categorized as disempowered (Malapit et al., 2019).

¹ The GPI is computed by comparing the empowerment scores of an individual woman with her spouse/male respondent in each household (dual-adult households). It reflects: (1) the percentage of women who enjoy gender parity; a woman enjoys gender parity if: she is empowered or if her empowerment score is equal to or greater than the empowerment score of the primary man/spouse in her household; (2) the empowerment gap – the average percentage shortfall that a woman without parity experiences relative to the man in her household. For details about computation of GPI, see Malapit et al. (2019).

Qualitative data were analyzed following a rigorous and reflexive process drawing on the thematic approach. The first step involved field-based daily briefs to identify the emerging insights for follow-up during the subsequent interviews. After fieldwork, all data were subjected to further in-depth analysis using the ATLAS.ti22 qualitative software. The process involved transcription of audio interview recordings, coding, searching for themes, patterns and connections in relation to the study objectives.

3 Findings

3.1 Status of rural women's empowerment

Based on the Pro-WEAI scores, the findings show an empowerment level of 0.78, computed from the weighted individual average of the 3DE score for women (0.76) and the gender parity index (GPI) score at 0.92. According to the pro-WEAI, individuals with a 3DE score above 0.75 (adequate in 9/12 indicators) are considered to be empowered. In our sample, only 42% of women met this threshold compared to 48% of the men, with this difference statistically significant at 10% level. The GPI showed that 63% of households achieved gender parity with an average empowerment gap of 22% for women who did not achieve gender parity as men in their households. Findings further show that the mean adequacy (3DE) score for the disempowered women is at 0.58, meaning that these women achieved adequacy in an average of 58% of the indicators compared to the men whose mean adequacy (3DE) score was at 0.59. This indicates that they achieved adequacy in an average of 59% of the indicators, denoting a small and statistically insignificant gender difference in terms of indicator adequacy. However, these aggregate measures mask interesting patterns within the indicators of empowerment. *Figure 1* shows the absolute contribution of each indicator to disempowerment (1-3DE score) for both women and men. Interestingly, the largest six contributors to disempowerment (work balance, attitudes about domestic violence, control over use of income, self-efficacy, respect among household members and autonomy in income) were similar for both women and men. However, attitudes about domestic violence play a larger role in women's disempowerment than men.

The findings indicate that indicators associated with intrinsic agency such as autonomy in decision-making, self-efficacy, attitudes towards domestic violence, and respect among household members are substantial contributors to women's disempowerment (*Fig. 1*). Other substantial contributors to women's disempowerment are aligned to instrumental agency indicators, particularly, control over use of income, work balance and input in productive decisions (*Fig. 1*). In contrast, a small proportion of women (18.7%) were considered to be

Table 1 Overall adequacy for men and women

Variable	N	(1)		(2)		t-test Difference (1)–(2)
		Men (mean/SE)	N	Women (mean/SE)		
Ownership of land and other assets	640	1.000 [0.000]	640	0.938 [0.010]		0.063***
Control over the use of income	638	0.433 [0.020]	637	0.386 [0.019]		0.046*
Access to and decisions on credit	640	0.869 [0.013]	617	0.911 [0.011]		−0.042**
Input in livelihood decisions	640	0.758 [0.017]	640	0.816 [0.015]		−0.058**
Membership in influential groups	640	0.855 [0.014]	640	0.784 [0.016]		0.070***
Group membership	640	0.900 [0.012]	640	0.895 [0.012]		0.005
Autonomy in income	640	0.613 [0.019]	640	0.641 [0.019]		−0.028
Visiting important locations	639	0.793 [0.016]	608	0.887 [0.013]		−0.093***
Attitudes about domestic violence	640	0.689 [0.018]	640	0.383 [0.019]		0.306***
Respect among household members	640	0.519 [0.020]	640	0.566 [0.020]		−0.047*
Self-efficacy	640	0.470 [0.020]	640	0.503 [0.020]		−0.033
Work balance	616	0.458 [0.020]	631	0.187 [0.016]		0.271***

The values displayed for *t*-tests are the differences in the means across the groups.
 ***, ** and * indicate significance at the 1, 5 and 10 percent levels, respectively.

Source: Field data, 2022.

adequately empowered in the domain of work balance compared to 45.8% of men (Table 1). Concerns around work balance are connected with the labour-intensive nature of subsistence farming, the main livelihood source, especially for women. The production season in these communities begins in February with planting, followed by weeding and harvesting with women contributing substantial labour as a female key informant (Agricultural Officer from Alebtong District) mentioned: ‘the women are the ones who put in a lot of effort from planting, wedding, harvesting. It is the women who are really involved there’.

Such farm labour performed by women comes on top of their socially established domestic responsibilities, including chores (washing dishes, cooking) and management of children’s wellbeing. Although there are narratives that men focus on income-generating activities, and this gendered division of activities is perceived to be ‘natural’ to men and women, there can be a double burden of work balance for women as further demonstrated by the following voices:

In our culture as Lango there are things that are automatic and everybody’s role at home is clearly defined like washing clothes is a woman’s responsibility unless in some cases where a man sees that madam is tired or has got a lot to do that is when he will help but this role has existed even before we were born a woman knows her role and a man knows his role like taking livestock to graze is a man’s role but in other households even women participate in grazing animals but that depends on

arrangement in that particular household. (FGD, Male, Abia Subcounty, Alebtong District, 2022)

Considering control over the use of income, only 38.6% of women reported adequate control over the use of income as compared with 43.3% of men (Table 1), a difference that was statistically significant. Women in the group discussions and interviews acknowledged that women have limited access to finance, but particularly stressed the gendered control of income. The women stressed that for the sake of peace in the home, they feared to challenge men's absolute control over income:

Let truth be told. Men do not want to work and yet they want to spend like men who work. The only way they can get money is to sell what the woman has produced from her sweat. It can be livestock; goats, chicken at home. At home also they do not want to work and they want to show that they still have authority. They know if the woman gets money, they will be less of men without their own money, so, they take away the woman's money to keep her in a begging state. Men have killed women when it comes to the point of selling, so, if you want your life you leave whatever you have harvested to go, and you retain peace. So, men want to be in charge of money so that women keep begging from them, they limit women. Women will never look smart, women will never eat good sauce at home and to him, that is what makes him a man. He even tells fellow men that at his home, it is only him to authorize the use of a piece of soap, if he does not buy salt no one can in his home and he feels respected that way. (Seasonality Calendar, Masha Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

Men held a view that control over money and assets defines one's social position in society, with the corollary that women should rely on their husbands for financial support:

They know [meaning men] if the woman gets money, they will be less of a man without their own money, so they take away the woman's money to keep her in a begging state. So, men want to be in charge of money so that women keep begging from them, they limit women, women will never look smart, women will never eat good sauce at home and to him that is what makes him a man. He even tells fellow men that at his home, it is only him to authorize the use of a piece of soap, if he does not buy salt no one can in his home and he feels respected that way. (Seasonality Calendar, Masha Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

In contrast to this, almost all women in the study (91.1%) indicated they were adequately empowered in terms of access to and control over credit, a higher proportion than that for men (86.9%) (Table 1). However, this is likely to be an artifact of our sample recruitment process, which selected households through women's membership in savings groups, many of which operate rotating credit funds. These groups, which can be understood as a collective empowerment strategy, were often mentioned by women, as demonstrated in some of their narratives below:

...there is a group that has started an association, and people can borrow from them. (Mixed sex Community Profile, Abia Subcounty, Alebtong District, 2022)

We have groups, where we save our money. Now when times of shocks come, you go to those groups, borrow money from them which have small interest and do not need collateral like in the bank. We use that money to pay school fees, to build, to take patients to the hospital, to buy food for family. (Mixed sex Community Profile, Kikagata Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

Collective agency indicators, consisting of group membership and membership in influential groups, contribute relatively little to both women's and men's disempowerment in our study. Much as with credit, through savings organizations, women are increasingly engaged in other groups such as religious organizations as expressed below:

Even in churches you find the majority are women praying and attending those discussion groups at church that encourage harmony in homes and are hardworking. All this is because women want to earn some money and become empowered, women are educating their children because men have stopped minding. At home, women are the ones who wake up very early and leave their drunk husbands in bed to go and work for their families. Men are getting unempowered because they are engaged in useless things like alcohol. (Women FGD, Masha Sub county, Isingiro District, 2022)

Table 1 presents the pro-WEAI measures of empowerment for both men and women, with the final column indicating differences between men and women and whether the differences are statistically significant.

3.2 Local understanding of empowerment and social-cultural dynamics

Qualitative data from focus group discussions and life histories indicate that men and women had varied definitions of empowerment most aligned to the three domains of empowerment (3DE) especially, instrumental agency.

3.2.1 Positive perceptions and characteristics of empowered women

Both men and women expressed their understanding of empowerment in terms of having access to finances and ability to make decisions over productive resources especially land, buildings, livestock, transportation and business. Financial capabilities were valued as empowering due to the desire to meet household needs. Having access to (or ownership of) productive resources such as land, livestock (goats, cows), income generating activities and a big farm was considered a key characteristic for an empowered woman, across

all study sites. Women with such resources command fear and respect in their communities as expressed below:

When a woman cultivates a garden and after harvesting the man allows her to sell the produce and then she buys a goat for the home which later becomes a cow. There you can do big things that everyone can see.... (FGD, Female, Mbaare Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

Most times people fear such a woman. People will say she is an empowered woman and the one who will develop such an area. She will go, make some money that can be used to develop the home so people are also respected. This happens because she is not just any woman who sits down unemployed. (FGD, Male, Abako Subcounty, Alebtong District, 2022)

Okay, the way I see an empowered woman is that woman who participates in small businesses to raise income to cater for the family. (Empowered Male, Omoro Subcounty, Alebtong District, 2022)

Therefore, being empowered means being hardworking and having the capability to earn an income that meets essential household basic needs including children's school fees and household food. Having a formal job or business was considered respectful, a description related to a culturally ideal woman as expressed by a woman from Abako sub-county, Alebtong district: 'works so hard that when you see her home you just know that home is for an empowered woman.' The above perceptions were attributed to women because of their increased exposure to education that accords them an opportunity to make private money: '...because they are educated, they make money on their own...' (Female KII Alebtong). Other descriptions related to owning better homes (developed, good looking, with basic needs to better care for their families, especially children). Better home care, especially children's good discipline, is considered a key characteristic of an empowered and well-behaved woman as explained below:

Such an empowered woman is the one who brings an opinion in her home and that opinion is considered. Her children look good, are educated, well disciplined, and are not smugglers of goods to the neighbouring country. Also, such a woman takes part in the decisions of her family with her husband. She is never left behind, their home looks good, she dresses decently and she is confident.... Any woman who decides on something and she does it, she is empowered.... (Empowered Female Life History, Kikagate Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

Findings further show that being a leader or simply an advisor in the community was regarded as empowering. An empowered woman from Abako subcounty in Alebtong district said: 'Yes, I am empowered because most of the women come to me for help and advice and I help them'. Empowered women were described to have decision-making power and authority with regard to the ability to participate in economic, production decisions and other decisions within the household either alone or jointly with a partner/husband. Such

women are considered to have the ability to plan for their lives and to put their plans into action. For others, being empowered is being in a position to make decisions without consulting a husband, a description related to a culturally ideal woman, as depicted below:

That is a woman that does what she feels like doing. She is a woman that does not consult the husband at home when she is going to do something. That is a woman that never agrees with the husband to do anything. Each one in the family does her, or his own things.... (Empowered Female, Life History, Ngarama Sub-county, Isingiro District, 2022)

Empowered women were also defined by their ability to make decisions. Such women tend to be valued as community role models as the following voices depict:

In village, for a woman that makes decision together with her husband, some people are actually going to give him a lot respect because you will find that such a man has good plans for his future and the family and he also has a well-established household. (Male, FGD Abako Subcounty, Alebtong District, 2022)

We admire a woman that cooperates with the husband and does one thing as a family. They sit as family and agree as a family.... (Empowered Female Life History, Ngarama Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

A woman who decides on something and puts it into action is a hero. And men think that such a woman is the head of the family.... (FGD, women, Mbaare subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

When other women see such women that make decisions with their husbands, they admire her, she is their role model.... (Female KII, Ngarama subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

Independent decision-making especially on economic matters (loosely termed 'economic independence') including the ability of women to provide for her family independently, and having access to everything was critical in defining an empowered woman by men. Such a woman is seen as an 'income source' and is seen to be a husband's financial saviour as expressed below:

We respect this woman because she is not over reliant and dependent on the man for provisions but she has her own things going and such women make a home a better place to be because she relieves her man from some pressure to provide for the family. (FGD, Male, Aloii sub-county, Alebtong district, 2022)

Interestingly, some men expressed admiration and support for them to progress towards gaining a higher social-economic status. This was evidenced by some men who wished to have close connections with such women as their mothers, wives or mothers-in-law. Therefore, we found positive perceptions by both men and women about an empowered woman. However, there were negative views as well that presented ambivalences and tensions as below.

3.2.2 Complex ambivalences and tensions about an empowered woman

At the same time, an empowered woman was associated with negative perceptions that depicted complex contradictions grounded in the desire to preserve traditional gender relations, and male superiority/patriarchy. Empowered women were perceived as witches, proud, and incapable of managing and sustaining a good marriage life, including being unsuitable 'marriage material.' Empowered women were labeled as 'prostitutes', disrespectful, uncultured, or un-submissive women that are not worthy of marrying. There were narratives around the tendency of some men abandoning such women, divorcing, or separating from them while others just fear getting close to them. Further, they were equated to being 'too high to be under a man' and 'unable to take care of their marriages' with examples of such narratives are depicted below:

The first perception will be that such women are the ones ruling their families, whereas others would say that the women could have bewitched their husbands.... (Male KII, Agricultural Officer, Kikagata Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)
 ...Others think she gives orders in the home and the man follows them. Others think a man for such a woman is bewitched.... (FGD, women, Mbaare subcounty, Isingiro district, 2022)
 ...they ask her what she gave her husband. Here, there is still a belief that a woman bewitched the man.... (Female KII, Ngarama subcounty, Isingiro district, 2022)

As such, while empowered women are expected to work hard and provide for their families, which is a positive perception, at the same time, they are thought about negatively. They are therefore, meant to 'watch' their moves and actions especially in regard to how they express themselves before their husbands and the public, in order to keep within their socially confined roles and behaviours. Women expressed the negotiations around the interconnectedness of marriage values and income control dynamics as below:

...In most cases when a woman earns more money than a husband, it is a bit challenging. The man feels inferior, he feels less empowered. So, the woman has to mind the words she uses in a home or when you are making decisions, because the moment you try to be at the forefront, the tone that you use, the man might think that you are doing that because you are earning more than him and you have your money.... (Female KII, Ngarama Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)
 Once the public knows that the woman earns more than the man, they keep thinking that the woman is ruling the man in the home, she is the head of the family, she is the one that decides in a home. But it is the man and the woman who know how they manage... As a woman you need to know how to handle it if you value your marriage, and if the man does not torture you for earning more than him.... (Female KII, Ngarama Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

To navigate such complexities, women's narratives depict how they often have to let men take charge and control their lives and income, which eventually limits their agency and potential. Most women mentioned having to negotiate such contradictory practices in terms of what they prefer to do vis-à-vis their 'acted' actions, for the sake of keeping peace in their marital relations. These acts were regarded as 'wise moves' by the women if they were to navigate their survival in their patriarchal communities. Further, some men expressed displeasure with empowered women by associating them to being competitive with their husbands and other men to 'overthrow' their social positions. As such, such women were labelled as 'fellow men' something that men were countering by working hard to 'beat' such 'competition.' Below are some examples of such negative stereotypes:

They think that the woman has taken over now, so a man is under her control because he is doing domestic work. (Female FGD, Abako Subcounty, Alebtong District, 2022)

...The community also becomes resentful of such households where women decide together with their husbands. Men in such a household will be perceived as being controlled by their wives.... (Male KII, Agricultural Officer, Kikagata Subcounty, Isingiro District, 2022)

Some people will say such a man is overpowered by the woman because the woman runs all the affairs of his home yet it's actually their decision to do so. (Male, FGD Abako Subcounty, Alebtong district, 2022)

The findings on the local perceptions of empowerment present narratives that demonstrate mixed feelings about what characterizes an empowered woman. While they are partly admired, they are also demonized when their behaviours fall out of the traditional expectations, associated with a socially ideal and submissive woman. The findings thus revealed contradictory expectations and contestations about the empowered woman vis-à-vis an ideal woman. In this regard, women empowerment was viewed as a threat to male position, power and control, and thus as a danger to marriage/family stability and peace.

3.3 The varied social image of an empowered woman: what did we learn?

While women who work and earn their own income were considered to be empowered, findings indicate community tensions that relegate such women to negative stereotypes due to their non-conformity to the social ideals of a submissive woman. The local narratives about an empowered woman remain contradictory, characterized by positive descriptions of empowered women within the context of a rigid gender system and a strong observance of the

gender hierarchy. While the benefits of women's empowerment are appreciated, preference to work within the traditional gender system remains apparent with women's/men's empowerment viewed in the context of a proper/ideal woman and man, and any deviations creating tension in the family and the broader society/community.

Economically independent women were perceived to be uncultured and less submissive, competitors with their husbands and dangerous to marriage/family stability and peace. These perceptions are largely aligned to the traditional expectations of a married woman and keeping within the social gender hierarchy and associated norms. Yet empowered women were also appreciated as key role models and heroes.

Overall, the qualitative findings reveal contradictory expectations and contestations about the empowered woman vis-à-vis an ideal woman. In this regard, women's empowerment was viewed as a threat to male position, power and control, thus a danger to marriage/family stability and peace. Therefore, empowerment was closely linked to the social cultural gender system and patriarchal power. Such resistance to change slows the process of empowerment and continues to create hurdles for women to exploit their potential, within the agricultural sector. As Kabeer (1999, 2001) argues, women empowerment should address gender constraints around (i) resources that not only include access but also material, human and social resources; (ii) agency including processes of decision-making, negotiation and manipulation); (iii) achievements (wellbeing outcomes).

4 Social-cultural gender dynamics and women's empowerment: implications for gender-equitable agriculture in Uganda and beyond

4.1 Main contributors of women's disempowerment and gender inequality

As the findings depict, the limited women's control and autonomy over agricultural income remains an overarching constraint in Africa. This resonates with Sexsmith's et al. (2017) work that documents the five dimensions to gender inequality in African agriculture as: (i) land rights; (ii) productive resources; (iii) unpaid work and employment; and (iv) decision-making power. Aligned to this, the UN Women (2018) indicates that although women constitute a major agricultural labour force, only 13% own agricultural land. Many scholars across the continent (including Nigeria and Uganda) have also documented the difficulty for women in to access land and engage in more productive and lucrative agricultural opportunities (Chekene, and Kashim, 2018). In Uganda, majority of women express joint ownership of land

with their husbands but only a few have formal documentation of the land (Chekene and Kashim, 2018).

Quisumbing, Meinzen-Dick and Njuki (2019) highlight the importance of women's control over income for their own empowerment, and reinvestment in crops and value chains that are important for their wellbeing, food and nutrition security, and poverty reduction outcomes. Evidence shows that if women had equal access to skills, resources and opportunities as men, they would become powerful agents in the fight against hunger, malnutrition and rural poverty (Quisumbing, Meinzen-Dick and Njuki, 2019; UN Women, UNDP and World Bank, 2015).

FAO (2018) denotes that in many developing countries, including Africa, the agricultural sector is underperforming, and one reason is attributed to women's unequal access to resources and the necessary opportunities to be more productive. In relation to this, IFAD (2012) draws our attention to the urgent need to promote gender-equitable agricultural opportunities in order to level the ground. It has been postulated that successful efforts to promote women's economic empowerment not only impacts incomes but also builds self-confidence, enhances women's agency, and contributes to improved education, health and security outcomes for families (Maestre & Thorpe, 2016). If a rural woman is empowered, she is able to make choices about assets and services – such as land, rural credit, technology, irrigation, labour, knowledge and extension – that contribute towards nutrition (UN Women, 2018).

Further, the findings depict women's disempowerment in terms of work-life balance, due to the heavy burden of work and amidst strict gender rules. In many African societies, women and girls have been socialized to undertake unpaid domestic and care roles such as fetching water, cooking, family farming/gardening, collecting firewood, washing clothes, caring for the sick, elderly, children and other time-consuming domestic tasks (Maestre & Thorpe, 2016; UN Women, 2018). Women and girls are responsible for water collection in 80% of households that have no access to water in their premises (UN Women, 2018). In sub-Saharan Africa, an average of 85.7% of households rely on unclean fuels for cooking and heating, with devastating effects on women and children's health who often spend more time working around the home (UN Women, 2018; Maestre & Thorpe, 2016). Globally, women perform unpaid care and domestic work 2.6 times more than men (UN Women, 2018). Yet such contributions are often unrecognized, unvalued and unrewarded (Grassi, Landberg and Huyer, 2015; FAO, 2018; Maestre and Thorpe, 2016). Power relations and social norms shape the provision of care and allocate more responsibilities to women than men (Maestre and Thorpe, 2016; Ferrant, Pesando and Nowacka, 2014). The socialization process in many African societies enhances the gender division of roles, including care roles, and reinforces its continuity. Ferrant et al. (2014) links

unequal distribution of care responsibilities to discriminatory social institutions and gender role stereotypes.

While care work is critical for individuals, families, societies and economies to survive and thrive from generation to generation (UN Women, 2018), it is also challenging for women's productivity and wellbeing (Ali et al., 2015; Grassi et al., 2015). Broadly, while women in low-income countries provide 43% of the agricultural labour force, they mainly work as unpaid family labourers (UN Women, 2018). Many studies clearly show women's heavy workloads compared to men in Uganda (Kavuma et al., 2018; Acosta et al., 2015). This further limits women's mobility to access lucrative markets to sell their produce and to tap into agricultural income. Maestre and Thorpe (2016) have noted that often, men will easily have access to the market where they sell produce or buy inputs, compared to women, due to constrained mobility. Women also lack access to information regarding the choice and use of inputs that negatively affect their farming activities and associated outcomes (Maestre and Thorpe, 2016).

A qualitative study conducted in three districts of Uganda (Kaabong, Kabale and Kampala) in 2018 shows that both urban and rural women dominate the unpaid care work at an average of 32h for women and 6.8h for men, a week. This was found to be closer to the national estimate of 30 h spent on unpaid domestic care work by women, and 12 h by men per week (UBOS, 2017). Culture in these districts and much of Ugandan and African societies defines a good woman as a good cook who grows, harvests, peels, and sorts the food, fetches water and firewood, as well as serves the food with care and respect, and cleans the utensils (Guloba et al., 2018). Women are stereotyped as compassionate nurturers and therefore 'most suited' to perform care roles. On the other hand, men were stereotyped as mobile, impatient, and with limited time to perform care duties (Guloba et al., 2018). Cultural expectations associated with being a good wife and mother comes with women's time constraints that limit their participation in profitable agricultural opportunities.

Recognising care is the first step towards change. This should begin with understanding gendered roles and responsibilities, household dynamics and community or other social group dynamics that affect women's time, mobility and agency (Maestre and Thorpe, 2016). They further note that 'where women are unable to leave their house due to their care responsibilities, such as preparing meals at specific times of the day, and participate in marketing crops, they may lose control over the money that is earned from farming' (Maestre and Thorpe, 2016, pp. 4–5). Given that unpaid care restricts women's involvement in the labour market, it also affects overall productivity, economic growth and poverty reduction. In Uganda, child-care activities constrain women's ability to either supervise or perform labour activities on their plots (Ali et al., 2015), while in Mozambique, women respond to the multiple roles and time constraints by multi-tasking (Arora, 2014). Arora (2014) has argued that the difficult

trade-offs between agricultural work, income-generating activities, household maintenance and care activities limit women's leisure time in Mozambique. Studies have shown that reducing women's share of unpaid care work could increase agricultural labour productivity by 15%, and capital productivity by as much as 44% in certain countries (OECD, 2008).

When adult women do less care work because of other responsibilities, the work is usually transferred to paid workers, often, other women (daughters or grandmothers), or the quality of the care is compromised. Adolescent girls are particularly affected and may have to drop out of school to help with care work, perpetuating a cycle of inequality (Maestre and Thorpe, 2016). Social norms determine culturally acceptable roles for men as well as women, and men (and women) can face a backlash for contravening norms. Men who try to undertake more care tasks or women who try to undertake fewer may be considered 'unnatural'. Widespread evidence shows that criticism, shaming and violence are mechanisms used to enforce these 'natural' gender roles (Maestre and Thorpe, 2016).

One of the key steps to this constraint is for agricultural development programmes to carry out sex-disaggregated gendered market analysis and collect sex-disaggregated data that enables the identification of gendered household and community dynamics, such as roles and responsibilities. This will enable us to build evidence towards understanding women and men's time use as well as their access to and control over resources (Maestre and Thorpe, 2016). It is also important to recognize women's unpaid labour contributions and ensure equal pay, working conditions and benefits in agriculture. This requires overcoming the marginalization of poor rural women that stems from gender-based socio-cultural norms and practices rooted in capitalist and patriarchal systems at various scales (FAO, 2018).

The key finding around the disempowerment of women manifested through their higher acceptance of domestic violence (even higher than men's acceptance) and this needs urgent attention in Uganda and Africa as a whole. Domestic violence manifests in different forms: physical, emotional and sexual. For instance, while 26% of men reported that it is justified for a husband to beat his wife across five scenarios, including burning food or leaving children unattended, 61% of women were supportive of the vice.

4.2 Prioritization of economic/income resources: access and control rights

Finally, in tandem with the quantitative findings, qualitative data depicts that both women and men small-scale farmers prioritize access to finances and assets such as land, livestock (goats and cows), as well as the ability to make decisions over these resources, as the desirable ingredients for enhancing their

empowerment. As findings depict, in patriarchal Ugandan societies, there is a tendency to privilege men to access and control over productive resources through inheritance regimes. By contrast, women's access to and joint ownership of land is often at the mercy of the men/husbands, for as long as the marriage is stable (Gibson et al., 2014; Doss, Meinzen-Dick and Bomuhangi, 2014). UBOS (2018) indicates that only 7.7% of women in Uganda own agricultural land individually while 39.9% own agricultural land jointly with someone else (UBOS, 2018). The limited access to property and assets, such as land, not only limits the productive capacities of women but also prevents them from accessing financial resources such as credit (using land as collateral) to enable them to engage in productive investments, such as re-investing in their farms to increase production, add value to their products or invest in off-farm income diversification. A survey by the Financial Sector Deepening (2018) indicates that only 4% of women had access to credit from formal financial institutions, 1% from formal and informal lenders, 23% relied on informal sources (savings groups, burial societies), 15% relied on family and friends and over a half of the women (57%) did not have access to credit. Therefore, women have less access to assets and services that would enable them to increase their productivity and reduce their workload (IFAD, 2012).

Across all study sites, participation in decision-making (independently or jointly), and having autonomy over income was considered critical. However, women's seeking and owning of productive resources was only perceived to be socially acceptable if they combined this with their traditional gender roles, including care roles, else they wouldn't be respected and their marriages would be at stake. This shows that income ownership for women is not enough unless they keep performing their socially expected roles and behaviours. Increased women's economic independence is perceived to weaken men's authority. Challenging men's overall authority over household income comes with reprimands such as gossip, domestic violence and loss of respect for the woman. Such reprimands further work to reinforce such unequal and unfair gendered practices.

5 Conclusion and recommendations

We conclude that in Uganda, and many other African societies, women's disempowerment and gender inequality are closely linked to social and gender norms and identities, rooted in the capitalist-patriarchal system that privileges men and boys, and disadvantages women and girls. Our mixed-methods empirical evidence and complementary literature attests to the ongoing tensions and ambivalences around women empowerment in Africa that need intentional and targeted attention if we are to enable gender-equitable and sustainable agricultural systems in Africa. The local narratives

about an empowered woman remained contradictory, characterized by positive recognition and perception of empowered women but situated within contexts of rigid gender systems that strongly observe unequal gendered power relations. The high preference for empowered women to operate within their traditional gender system remains problematic for them to realize actual empowerment. The complexities of empowerment intricately connected to an ideal woman offer critical deviations from the global understanding of empowerment. These are seemingly creating hurdles for women to exploit their potential, including within the African agricultural systems.

We also conclude that the main contributors to women's disempowerment are aligned to the two domains of empowerment, namely, instrumental (work-life balance, control over use of income and autonomy in income) and intrinsic agency (self-efficacy, attitudes about domestic violence and respect among household members). This demonstrates the need to pay attention to these indicators if we are to promote gender equality and strengthen women's empowerment in through the agricultural sector. Some key recommendations are to enhance women's access to and control over resources, recognize, value, reduce and redistribute unpaid care work to free women's time to exercise their potential, and create a gender-responsive policy environment for women to function in informed by locally grounded gender evidence. An intentional gender transformative agenda will go a long way to address the structural gaps that limit women from engaging meaningfully in the agricultural sector in Uganda and Africa as a whole.

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7 Where to look for further information

For further information on the subject, please read the following publications:

- Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations. 2011. The State of Food and Agriculture; Women in Agriculture: Closing the Gender Gap for Development. (FAO, Rome, 2011); Link: <https://www.fao.org/3/i2050e/i2050e00.htm>

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Key research in this area can be found at the following organizations:

- Food and Agricultural Organization (FAO).
- International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI).

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